

Should *Nature* Streamline Its Final Submission Guidelines?

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Abstract

This policy analysis examines whether selected requirements in *Nature*'s final submission guidelines create administrative burdens that could be reduced without compromising scientific or editorial standards. Particular attention is directed toward requirements governing electronic image formats, display items, and extended data. Jiang et al. (2019) found that 91.1% of surveyed scientists supported more streamlined formatting requirements and estimated that manuscript reformatting imposes approximately \$1.1 billion in annual costs on the scientific community and funders. Against this backdrop, this analysis evaluates whether selected elements of *Nature*'s final submission protocol serve substantive scientific and editorial functions or primarily support production and presentation. The findings suggest that some requirements could be simplified, automated, or deferred until the production stage. Although this analysis does not directly measure the time or financial costs associated with *Nature*'s specific requirements, it argues that journal submission policies should distinguish more clearly between requirements necessary for scientific integrity and those that can be managed through modern publishing workflows.

Introduction

Scientific journals enforce submission standards to maintain publication quality, facilitate editorial workflows, and ensure consistency across published articles. However, extensive formatting requirements—particularly at the final acceptance stage—can impose administrative

labor on authors without materially affecting a manuscript’s scientific content or evaluation. *Nature*’s final submission guidelines contain detailed specifications for figures, electronic image formats, display items, and supplementary materials. While certain requirements remain essential for scientific accuracy, accessibility, reproducibility, or production quality, others primarily serve presentation or layout functions.

This distinction is important because formatting burdens are not necessarily proportional to their contribution to scientific evaluation. If a requirement can be reliably implemented by a publisher’s production system after acceptance, requiring authors to perform that transformation manually may represent an avoidable administrative cost.

This policy analysis asks which elements of *Nature*’s final submission requirements are necessary for scientific integrity or editorial assessment and which could instead be simplified, automated, or deferred until production. The focus is specifically on the final submission stage rather than the initial manuscript-submission process.

Methodology

This study employs a structured document analysis of *Nature*’s current final submission guidelines (2026), focusing on technical specifications governing electronic image formats, display items, and extended data displays.

Each requirement is evaluated against four criteria: (1) its relevance to scientific validity, accuracy, or reproducibility; (2) its role in peer review and editorial assessment; (3) its function in downstream production, presentation, or accessibility; and (4) its susceptibility to automation or deferral until the production stage.

To contextualize these institutional practices, the analysis cross-references empirical evidence from Jiang et al. (2019), who examined the resource implications of manuscript reformatting across scientific publishing. Their findings provide broader evidence concerning researcher preferences and the economic costs associated with formatting-related administrative work.

Because this investigation relies on textual and documentary analysis, it does not involve primary human-subject data collection or directly measure the exact time authors spend

complying with *Nature*'s requirements. Consequently, it does not attempt to calculate institution-specific or journal-specific cost savings.

Results

The analysis suggests that several elements of *Nature*'s final submission guidelines—including specifications for electronic image formats and display-item presentation—may create administrative burdens for authors while contributing relatively little to the scientific evaluation of a manuscript. Nevertheless, these requirements serve legitimate production functions, including facilitating typesetting, ensuring technical compatibility, and reducing errors during publication.

Recognizing the boundary between scientific and production functions is therefore important. A requirement may be useful to the publisher without requiring manual execution by the author at final submission. Where a task involves file conversion, layout normalization, or structural formatting, modern publishing systems may offer opportunities for automation or for transferring responsibility from authors to publishers.

These observations are consistent with Jiang et al. (2019), who reported substantial researcher support for streamlined formatting and identified significant resource expenditures associated with manuscript reformatting. While their data do not isolate the specific costs imposed by *Nature*, their findings indicate that formatting-related administrative work represents a meaningful burden across the scientific publishing ecosystem.

Overall, the analysis suggests that *Nature* could benefit from drawing a sharper distinction between requirements necessary for scientific verification and those primarily intended to facilitate production or visual consistency. The latter category warrants consideration for automation, simplification, or post-acceptance implementation.

Discussion

Editorial standards at leading journals such as *Nature* should be preserved when they directly contribute to scientific accuracy, accessibility, reproducibility, or reliable editorial assessment. The objective of streamlining is not to eliminate technical standards, but to reconsider who executes specific tasks and at what stage of the publication process.

Production-oriented consistency requirements could, where technically feasible, be automated through modern typesetting systems or deferred until after formal acceptance. Such an approach would preserve the publisher’s capacity to produce reliable articles while reducing unnecessary manual preparation by authors.

This distinction is especially relevant at the final submission stage. Because a manuscript has already undergone peer review and editorial evaluation, certain formatting details may have limited relevance to the decision to publish the underlying research. Requiring exhaustive manual compliance at this stage may therefore add administrative work when equivalent transformations could be performed reliably during production.

At the same time, not all formatting requirements are superfluous. File specifications, figure quality, accessibility considerations, and display standards can serve important technical functions that are not captured by scientific evaluation alone. A balanced policy objective is therefore to distinguish genuinely necessary requirements from those that could be automated or transferred to the publisher’s workflow.

Because this analysis lacks primary micro-level data on author hours or publisher processing expenses, its findings should be interpreted as a conceptual policy argument rather than a quantitative economic estimate. Nevertheless, the structural alignment between these findings and the broader evidence from Jiang et al. (2019) suggests that reducing unnecessary formatting labor is a worthwhile avenue for publishing-policy reform.

Conclusion

Nature is well-positioned to streamline its final submission guidelines by simplifying, automating, or deferring requirements that offer limited direct scientific or editorial value. Evidence

from Jiang et al. (2019), considered alongside the present analysis, indicates that manuscript formatting can impose meaningful administrative costs without necessarily producing proportional gains in scientific quality.

The goal should not be the removal of technical standards, but their appropriate timing. Requirements essential to scientific integrity, reproducibility, accessibility, or editorial assessment should remain rigorous, while production-oriented tasks that can be reliably managed by publishers should be automated or integrated into the production workflow.

Modernizing journal administration in this manner could reduce unnecessary author friction while preserving the rigorous standards expected of high-quality scientific publishing. Although this analysis centers on *Nature's* protocol, the underlying principle applies more broadly: scientific publishing policies should continually reassess administrative requirements as technological and production capabilities evolve.

References

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